Penn Libraries
University of Pennsylvania

CHOOSING A DIGITAL MAPPING PLATFORM FOR YOUR PROJECT

A workshop in the "Digital Humanist's Help Desk" series

October 16, 2026

Cynthia Heider, Public Digital Scholarship Librarian

Follow along with links at: **https://bit.ly/4ofzqkR**

OVERVIEW

With many options to choose from, picking the right tool for mapping your research in the humanities can be daunting. This session will guide participants through the pros and cons of various free and paid mapping tools and platforms like Google MyMaps, ZeeMaps, Felt, MapBox Studio, Leaflet, and ArcGIS Online. Special attention will be paid to evaluating your own source material, needs, and priorities to find the best tool for you and your project.

Learning goals:

- *Identify what kind of humanities data you have (or want) to create a digital project that incorporates mapping.*
- *Evaluate your resources and constraints relevant to choosing a mapping tool.*
- *Apply this knowledge to planning to create your own projects using the most appropriate tool(s) for your needs.*

WHO AM I?

Cynthia Heider



Public Digital Scholarship Librarian

Email: heider@upenn.edu
Book a consultation: www.library.upenn.edu/staff/cynthia-heider

What can I help with?

- Digital projects for public audiences
- Digital projects involving community partners
- Choosing the right tool or platform for your digital project
- Working with data in the humanities
- Connecting with digital project resources at and beyond UPenn

Research Data and Digital Scholarship (RDDS)

- Support across research data & digital scholarship lifecycles
- Encourage thoughtful and informed use of emerging technologies in our fields of expertise
- Aid in the creation & dissemination of traditional + cutting-edge scholarly outputs
- Provide custom workshops, in-class visits, and consultations (one-on-one or team-based).

Website: www.library.upenn.edu/RDDS
Email: LibraryRDDS@pobox.upenn.edu
Workshop calendar: bit.ly/RDDS-events



ROADMAP

Pre-planning your project

Resource mapping

Reviewing your project’s needs and priorities

Platform roundup

Questions and comments

PRE-PLANNING

What materials are you working with? What are your ideas for your project?

HUMANITIES RESEARCH DATA

What does data look like in the humanities?

correspondence
estate inventory
shipping manifest
diary or journal
financial ledger
photograph
drawing or other work of visual art
burial, birth, or wedding record
newspaper
property record or deed
tax list
notebook
memorandum
telegram
speech
material culture item
genealogy
recipe or menu
film, novel, or other cultural artifact
directory
logbook
blueprints
built structure
price list
advertisement
legislation
government proceedings
transcript
interview
autobiography
schematic or plan
diagram or chart
land survey or map
polling results
census
audio or video recording
publication

… and more!

EXERCISE: PRE-PLANNING

Choosing a Digital Platform for Your Project

Pre-planning:

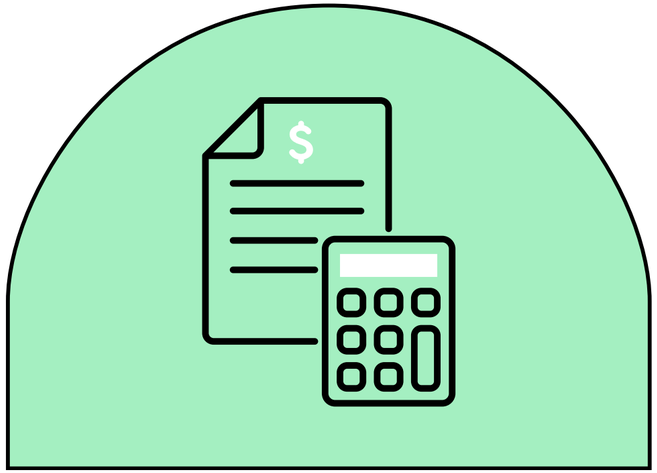
What materials are you working with? What are your ideas for your project?



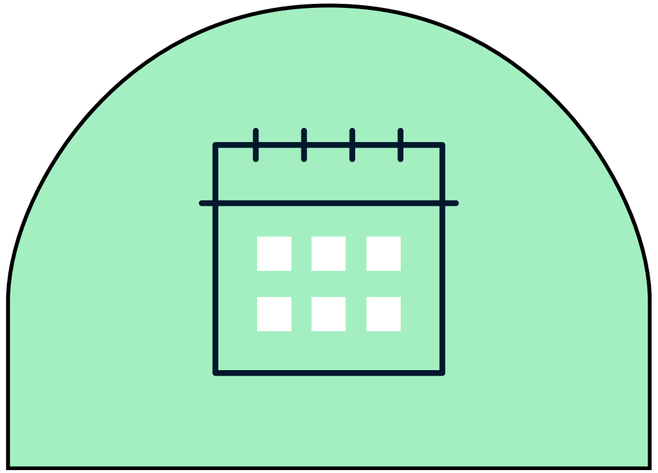
RESOURCE MAPPING

What resources and limitations do you need to keep in mind as you choose a tool?

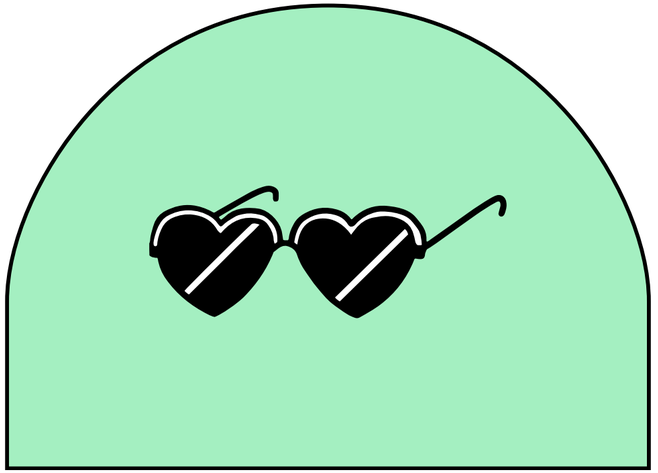
CHOOSE TWO



Inexpensive



Quick



Fancy

EXERCISE: RESOURCE MAPPING



I have more of…	I have less of…

Funding
Time
People/Labor
Training or comfort using new tech tools
Access to tools or data
Readiness of source material
Permission to use source material

NEEDS & PRIORITIES

What are your top 3 priorities?

EXERCISE: NEEDS & PRIORITIES



Needs & priorities:

Gain technical knowledge or experience	Quick to create
Privacy considerations	Free or low cost solution
Long-term sustainability	Complex or advanced functionality
Frequent updates or changes	Data/content export or download
Reaching a particular audience	Publication
Soliciting feedback or otherwise measuring engagement	Other?

ROUND ROBIN

What discipline are you coming from? What is your map idea?

PLATFORM ROUNDUP

GOOGLE MYMAPS

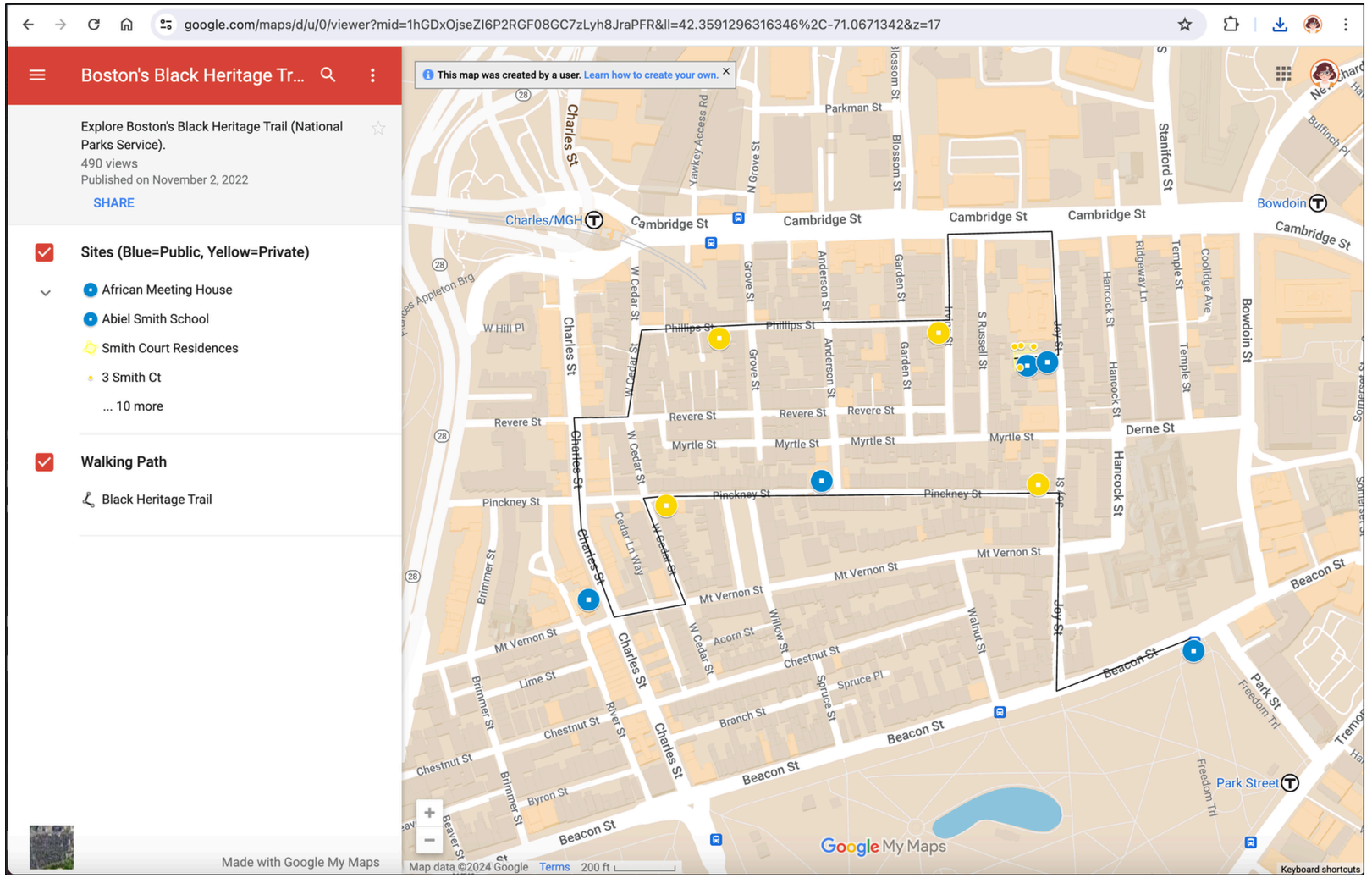
Example: Boston's Black Heritage Trail

Inexpensive



Quick





GOOGLE MYMAPS

Pros

- Very easy to use
- Easily import and export data in multiple formats

Cons

- Need to sign in with a Google account - which means Google owns your data
- Not particularly flashy or aesthetic
- Limitations on what you can display

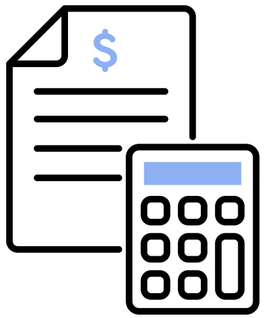
Use this tool if you…

- Have limited time or budget
- Are mapping for understanding rather than presentation

ZEEMAPS

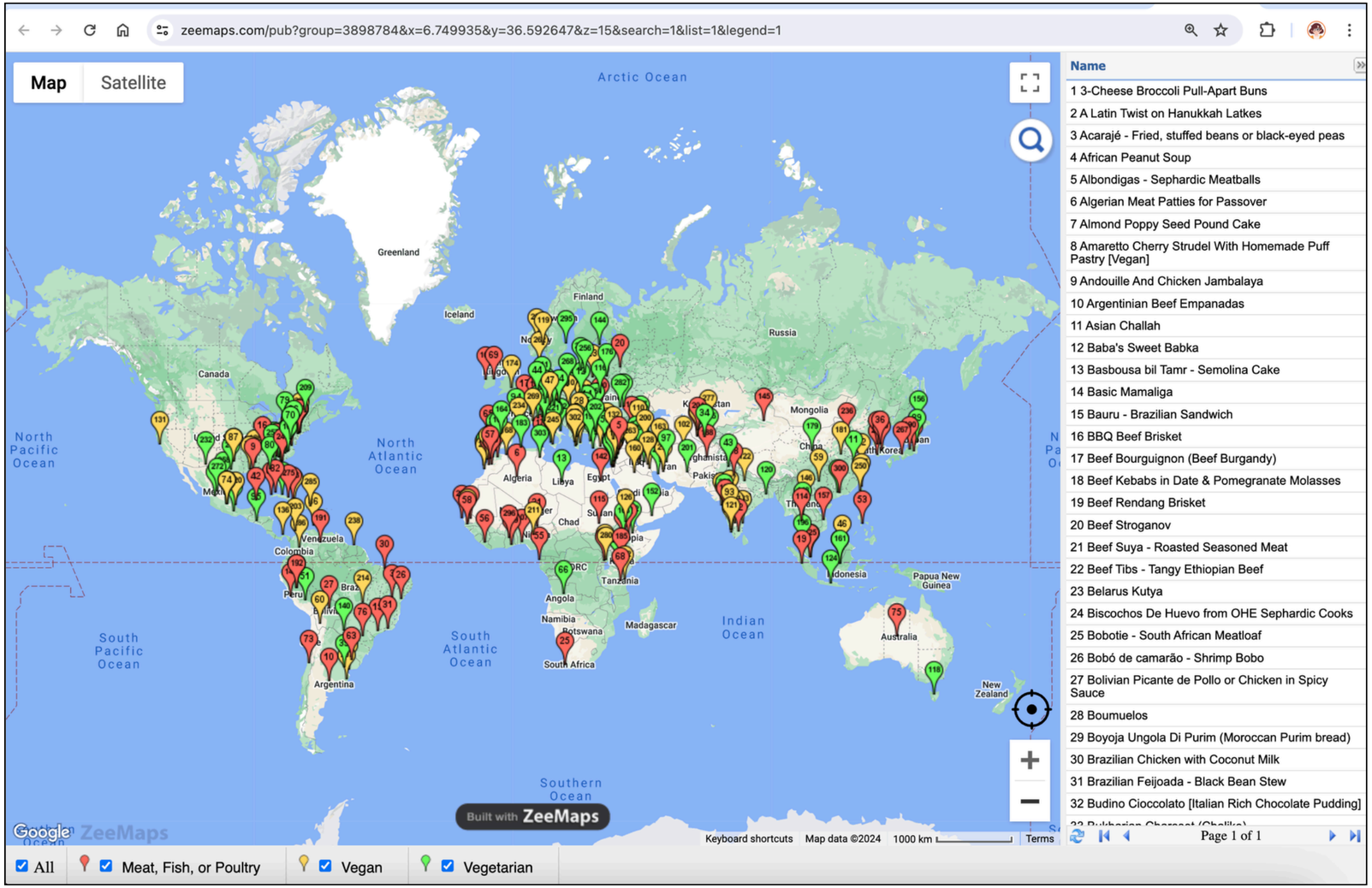
Example: World Map of Recipes

Inexpensive



Quick





ZEEMAPS

Pros

- Crowdsourcing capability
- Easy data import
- Data privacy measures (HIPAA compliant)

Cons

- Free up to a point
- Export not possible
- Limited functionality

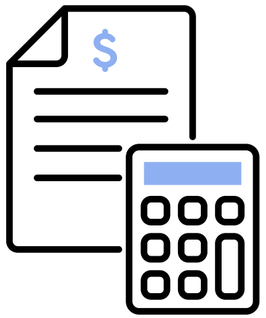
Use this tool if you…

- Have limited time or budget and want an alternative to Google products
- Need data privacy
- Would like to crowdsource

FELT

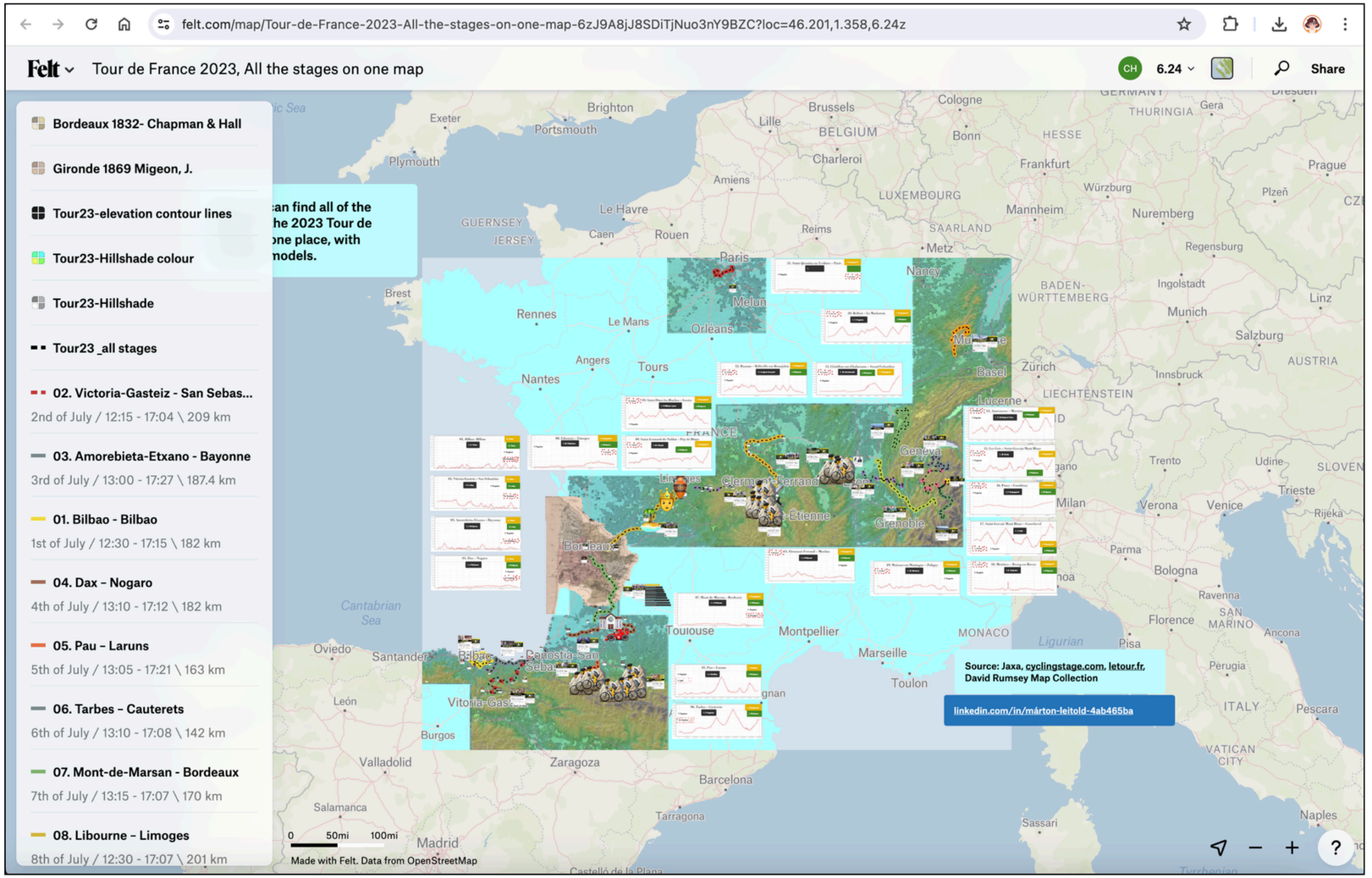
Example: Tour de France 2023

Inexpensive (for some)



Fancy





FELT

Pros

- Aesthetic and interactive
- Allows for multiple data sources and types
- Annotatable maps (add pins, drawings, polygons, text, photos, docs, and video)

Cons

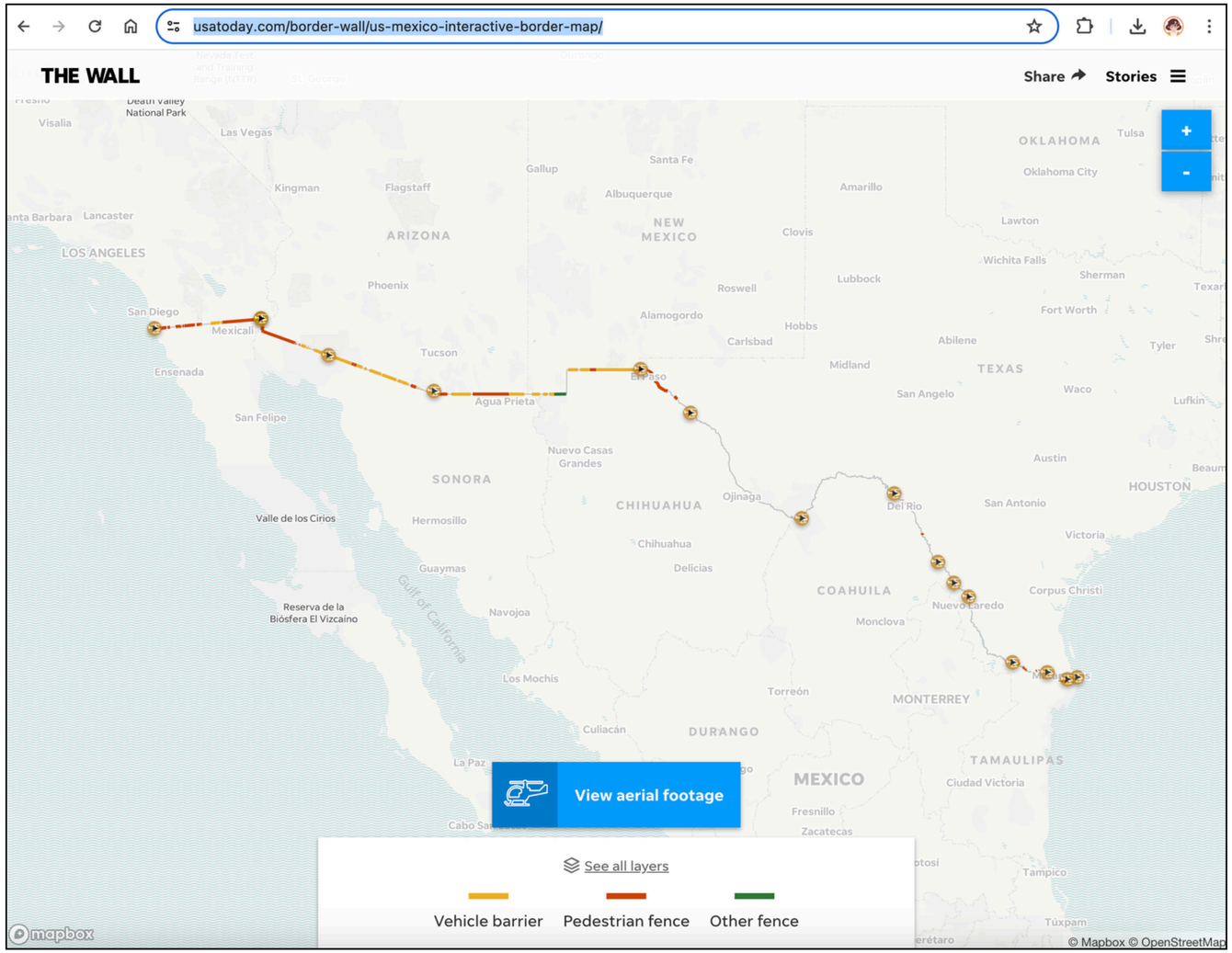
- Very limited free tier; most features are paid (if you are an instructor, you can get verified for a free higher tier account)
- Takes a little practice to get the hang of it

Use this tool if you…

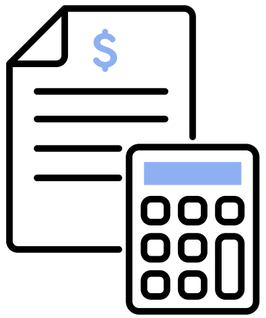
- Are an educator and can get premium features for free
- Have some time and want to learn more about GIS

MAPBOX STUDIO

Example: USA Today “The Wall” interactive map



Inexpensive



Fancy



MAPBOX STUDIO

Pros

- Easily import and export data in multiple formats
- Lots of customization options - many use a simple interface
- Great tutorials and product support for learning the platform

Cons

- Free up to a point
- Combining multiple data sources and types can be challenging and may require data cleanup/normalization beforehand
- Learning curve

Use this tool if you...

- Need to use multiple formats of data
- Have some time to learn the ins and outs of the platform

LEAFLET

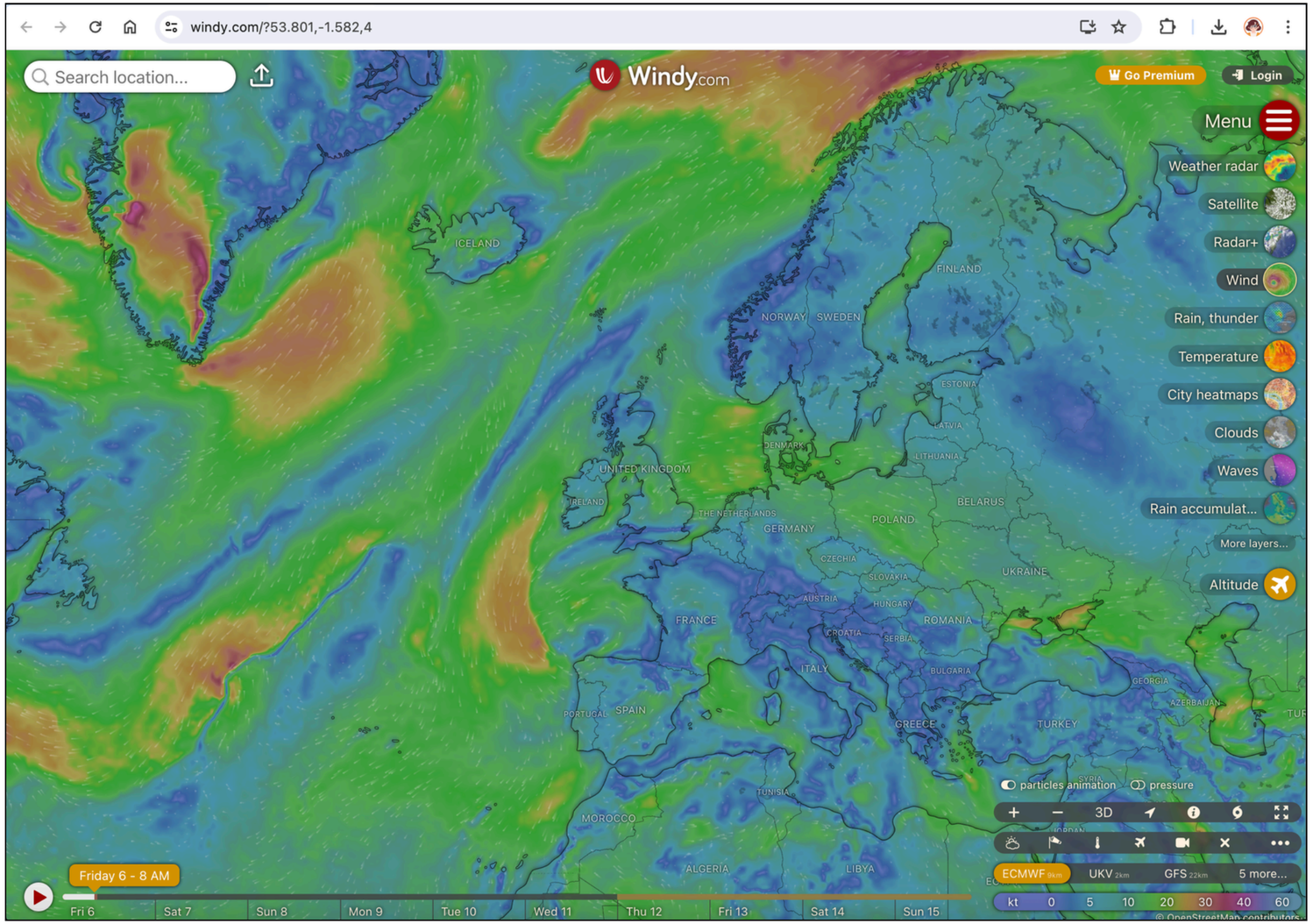
Example: “Windy”

Inexpensive



Fancy





LEAFLET

Pros

- Free and open source
- Very customizable

Cons

- Requires some knowledge of HTML, CSS, and JS
- Need your own web server to host maps, site, and data

Use this tool if you…

- Have some experience building websites or the budget to hire someone who does
- Want complete control over the data and design of your map

ARCGIS ONLINE

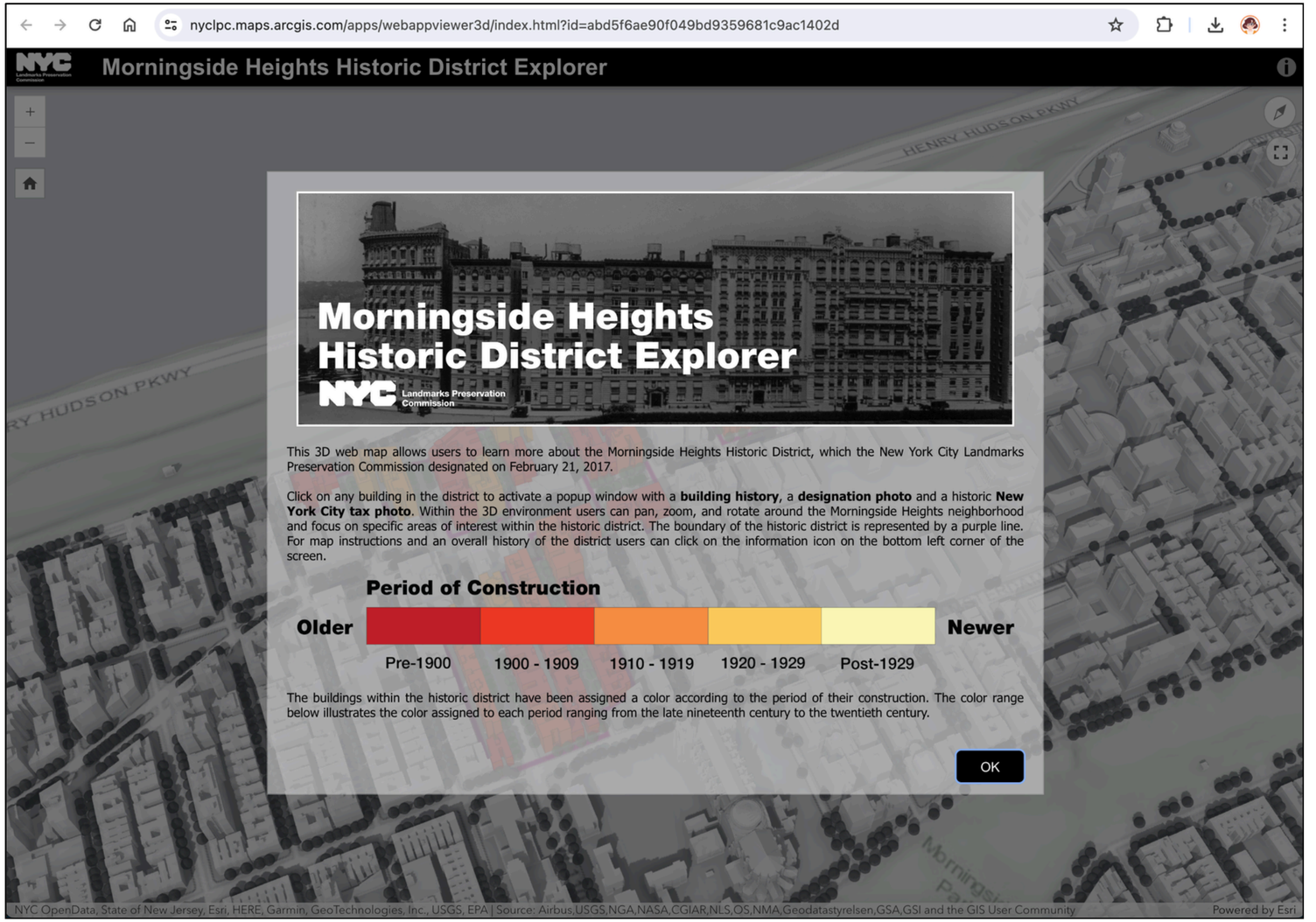
Example: Morningside Heights Historic District Explorer

Inexpensive (for some)



Fancy





ARCGIS ONLINE

Pros

- Aesthetic
- Lots of support for learning and creating (online and through the Penn Libraries)
- Robust capabilities

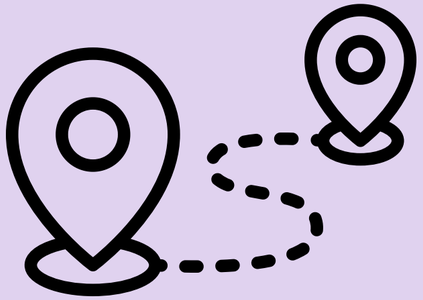
Cons

- Requires an expensive subscription, like the one offered by Penn
- Learning curve can be steep depending on complexity of features you want to use

Use this tool if you…

- You want something that looks really good
- You have a lot of time or a budget
- You want to jump into the deep end of GIS and mapping

MORE RESOURCES



Penn resources

GIS & Mapping Resources Research Guide

Schedule a consultation

Email support or create an Esri/ArcGIS account: LibraryGIS@pobox.upenn.edu

Penn GIS Day event (November 19)

General resources

“Beyond Esri” resource guide

Spatial Humanities Workshop by Lincoln Mullen

Other GIS Day 2025 events and resources

QUESTIONS & COMMENTS

THANK YOU!

Contact me!

- Email: heider@upenn.edu
- Book a consultation: www.library.upenn.edu/staff/cynthia-heider

Download these slides and the worksheet

- https://github.com/cynthiaheider/choosing-map

Fill out a brief survey

- tinyurl.com/rdds26